

CMF Headphone Pro

Flashy design and fun sound at a compelling price

I've been watching the sub-Rs 10,000 headphone market get crowded lately.

The popular ones already tick the basics: ANC, long battery life, app support, decent sound. So, standing out usually comes down to how well a brand does one or two things better than everyone else. The newly launched CMF Headphone Pro, priced at Rs 6,999 in the introductory period, tries that with a unique design and up to 100-hour battery life. It also packs interesting specs like Hi-Res LDAC support, hybrid ANC up to 40 dB, Bluetooth 5.4, etc. And in my testing, I wanted to see if CMF's feature sheet translates into real value at this price and whether the design and other choices by the Nothing sub-brand make sense. Let's dive in.

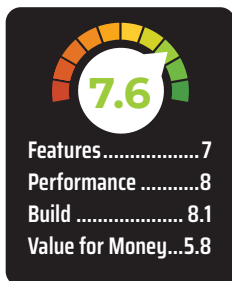
DESIGN

The CMF Headphone Pro immediately grabs attention with its cute and flashy look. Our review sample is teal coloured with a glossy finish on the metal rail and earcups. Whenever I put it on, in the office, in the metro, or at home, people around me would glance at it or even ask about it. It has a distinct and intentional appearance. But that can be subjective, and not everyone's cup of tea. I would have preferred the light or dark grey variants instead.

There is a subtle 'CMF by Nothing' branding on the earcups. Both earcups also offer a nice physical interface to easily control settings:

- The roller wheel on the right earcup lets you lower or raise the volume. Pressing it, you can play or pause music and answer or drop calls.

₹6,999



There are similar preset functions for double-press and triple-press. You can configure the press-and-hold to switch between ANC and Transparency.

- Below this roller, there is a customisable button with some options.

- On the other hand, the left earcup houses a power cum pairing button and a slider to tweak the bass/treble level. The slider does work without the app, which is fun if you want a quick thump boost.

While a physical interface allows more precise control mechanisms, it may demand some learning curve. Besides the buttons, the right earcup has a USB-C port, and the left earcup has a 3.5mm headphone jack. CMF packs a 3.5mm aux cable in the box.

Coming to comfort, the large and plush ear cushions offer good over-ear seal, and the cushioned headband also sits finely on the head. At 283 grams,

with a plastic, metal, and synthetic leather material combination, the headphone is light and comfortable in daily use. The clamp force is negligible. You can easily twist and swap those ear cushions. The respective L and R markings inside let you replace them and also put on the headphones properly.

You can rotate the earcups flat. This could aid in packing and carrying them on your neck. But, no folding hinge here. The given IPX2 water resistance is weak, but at least you get some assurance from sweat and drizzle, which many headsets in the range don't give.

NOTHING X APP

Pressing the pairing/power button on the left earcup for a few seconds begins pairing mode, and you'll get a fast pairing notification on nearby Android phones. The headphones have Bluetooth 5.4, and the connection stays stable. It supports the Dual Connection feature, letting you connect to two devices and switch playback between them. You'll have to pause one to start playing from the other. Not a flaw; just how it works. In any case, if you want it, you'll have to enable it within the Nothing X app.

The Nothing X app lets you choose a higher-resolution LDAC codec, switch ANC levels, toggle Spatial modes (Concert/Cinema), calibrate personal sound profile, Find Headphones, enable Low Lag mode with less than 120ms latency claim, Standby mode, and a simple EQ with some presets. This is a very simple EQ interface with some useful presets, but far from a full parametric EQ.

There's no wear-detection-based playback feature, which can be annoying if you remove the headphones from your ears and the music continues playing.

BATTERY AND CHARGING

Battery life is arguably this headphone's biggest bragging point. CMF claims 'up to 100 hours' of playback with ANC off and around 50 hours with ANC, AAC and at 50% volume. In my test, I got 37.5 hours with ANC, LDAC, and continuous